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Key drivers will be high-end televisions and washers

—Sabiha Kidwai, marketing manager, Panasonic India



from giants such as Intel and Samsung Electronics to contract manufacturers such as Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing all expect weak sales in the coming quarters.

The global semiconductor revenue is expected to fall 16.3 per cent in 2009 to \$219.2 billion after a 4.4 per cent fall in 2008, due to the economic slowdown, according to research firm Gartner.

Though high-end luxury items are likely to suffer the most, especially in the consumer electronics space, the exception will be so-called smartphones, including Apple's iPhone and RIM's Blackberry products. Many consumers in 2009 will upgrade from plain-old cell phones to gadgets that do e-mail and offer Web access, and they'll increasingly buy special services or software especially designed for the mobile Web.

Beyond smartphones, the big sellers in technology will be products and services that help companies and consumers save money or work more efficiently. One noticeable trend here will be increased sales of mini-notebook computers. Already, portable computers such as laptops are selling more than desktops, and an increasingly important part of the mix will be mini-notebook computers. Known as netbooks, these mini-notebook computers are stripped-down portables with no DVD drive and a lot less

processing power. For people needing a computer for simple applications like Internet access, a lot of functionality of a computer goes unused, and cheaper netbooks fit here as a good alternative.

Computer makers are estimated to have sold more than 11 million netbooks worldwide in 2008—up from just around a million in 2007—and netbook sales could easily double in the new year.

India, an exception?

If we go by the words of Sabiha Kidwai, marketing manager, Panasonic India, the consumer electronics situation in India appears rather rosy. Kidwai says that the consumer electronics industry is growing in India and has a lot more potential. The industry has witnessed significant growth in recent years due to several factors, such as retail boom, growing disposable income and finance schemes. High-ticket items are selling mainly in metropolitan cities and low-ticket items in tier-2 and tier-3 towns. Innovations are appealing and touching Indian consumers through consumer electronics. Blu-ray and full high-definition are the new technologies attracting consumers.

The consumer electronics industry will most likely grow in India at a rate of 10 per cent overall in value. Convergence makes this industry

The growing demand for better energy management, better healthcare and energy conservation will increase adoption and growth in the market despite the downturn.